



SWMS18

Safe Work Method Statement

Work in or near water or other liquid that involves a risk of drowning

Document number	EC-SWMS18	Revision	1.0
Prepared by	Ecology Consulting — WHS / Field team	Document release date	
Approved by	Tony Webster — Managing Director / WHS Officer	Next review	

Note: Work must be performed in accordance with this Safe Work Method Statement (SWMS). This SWMS must be kept and available for inspection until the work is completed. If revised, every version must be kept. If a notifiable incident occurs in relation to the work in this SWMS, the SWMS must be kept for at least two years from the date of the notifiable incident. This SWMS is accessed and acknowledged through the Ecology Consulting digital WHS platform; field forms are submitted from site and reviewed centrally by the administration team.

Scope & limitations: Works are limited to controlled ecological survey activities only. **Personnel will not enter water where conditions are unsafe or where rescue cannot be immediately performed.** Where risks cannot be adequately controlled, work will not proceed. Ecology Consulting personnel are not trained water rescue specialists and **will not enter water to conduct a rescue unless trained and authorised.** No diving work is undertaken.

Project & PCBU details

Person conducting a business or undertaking (PCBU)	Ecology Consulting Pty Ltd · ABN 68 647 633 163	Contact number	0472 569 988 (office / Check-in)
EC offices	34 Atchison St, Wollongong NSW 2500 · 42 Goulburn St, Crookwell NSW 2583 · 473 Townsend St, Albury NSW 2640		
Client / Principal Contractor			
Work activity	Ecological survey and monitoring in or near rivers, creeks, dams, wetlands, billabongs, drainage lines and other water bodies, including flora and fauna survey and dewatering supervision.		
Workplace location			
Field work duration			

Legislation, codes of practice & standards

Acts & Regulations	Work Health and Safety Act 2011 (NSW) and the Work Health and Safety Regulation (NSW); Work Health and Safety Act 2011 (Cth) and WHS Regulations 2011 (Cth) where work is on Commonwealth land or for a Commonwealth entity (Comcare jurisdiction); Work Health and Safety Act 2011 (ACT) and WHS Regulation 2011 (ACT) for works in the ACT.
Codes of Practice	Safe Work Australia model Codes as adopted in NSW and the ACT: <i>How to manage work health and safety risks; Work health and safety consultation, cooperation and coordination; Construction work; First aid in the workplace; Managing the work environment and facilities; Preparation of safe work method statements for construction work. Managing the risk of falls at workplaces; Managing the work environment and facilities.</i>
Standards & guidance	AS 4758 Personal flotation devices; AS/NZS 2210 Occupational protective footwear; AS/NZS 4602 High visibility safety garments; AS/NZS 1801 Occupational protective helmets. SES and BOM flood and rainfall warning services.
EC WHS documentation	EC Work Health and Safety Management System and WHS Handbook; EC Risk Management Processes (EC-RMP-FRM-001); EC Hazard Register and Trigger Action Response List (TARL); Pre-Mobilisation Checklist; Pre-Travel Vehicle Safety Checklist; Journey Management Plan; Daily Toolbox Talk; site-specific Emergency Response Plan (ERP); JSA — General Field Surveys; JSA — Remote and Isolated Work; SOP — Journey Management; SOP — Terrestrial Fauna; SOP — Fieldwork Biosecurity. SOP — Dewatering Activities; SWMS01 — Risk of a person falling more than two metres.

Mandatory personal protective equipment & field equipment

Confirmed present and serviceable on the Pre-Mobilisation Checklist and verified by the Field Lead at the Daily Toolbox Talk. Faulty items are tagged out and removed from service.

Hard Hat	Safety Glasses	Gloves	Hearing Protection	Hi-Vis Clothing	Sun Safe PPE	Wide Brim Hat	Capped Boots
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Fire Extinguisher	Remote First Aid Kit	Snake Bite Kit	In Reach / Sat Phone	Two-Way Radio	Torch / Headlamp	GPS	Drinking Water
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Buoyancy Aid / PFD	Floating Rescue Rope (min 20 m)	Reaching Aid / Pole	Waders (see note)	Non-Slip Footwear	Waterproof Comms	Kayak (where approved)	Spare Dry Clothing
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Hierarchy of controls

Eliminate	Avoid working in or near water wherever practicable by redesigning survey methods — conduct surveys from banks, bridges or elevated positions, and use binoculars, cameras, drones or existing data instead of entering water.
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Substitute	Use safer survey methods that reduce exposure to drowning risk — undertake work in shallow or dry areas, use extendable tools or remote sensors, or adjust timing to avoid high water levels or flow conditions.
Isolate	Establish and maintain exclusion zones around deep water, fast-flowing areas, unstable banks and flood-prone zones; restrict access to hazardous areas and maintain safe setback distances at all times.
Engineer	Use available engineered controls such as fixed platforms, designated crossings, handrails, barriers, stable entry and exit points, and controlled access locations; use existing infrastructure rather than natural or unstable banks.
Administrative	SWMS, site-specific risk assessments, weather and hydrology checks including upstream conditions, minimum team requirements (buddy system), communication protocols, emergency and rescue plans, and clearly defined stop-work triggers; enforce no entry into unsafe water conditions under any circumstances.
PPE	Last line of defence only — personal flotation devices where required, non-slip footwear, helmets where applicable and suitable clothing. PPE must not be relied upon as the primary control for drowning risk.

Hazards & controls

Complete for each water body. Safe entry and exit points must be identified before work commences.

What are the hazards & risks	What are the control measures	Select relevant controls (completed onsite by Field Lead)
Planning, preparation and travelling to site		
Inadequate planning leading to uncontrolled risk; unfit or untrained personnel	Attend the pre-field meeting with the Project Lead and Project Manager to review scope, methodology and expected hazards; confirm site access, keys, codes, inductions and property constraints; and confirm all staff are trained, competent and fit for work. Medical concerns are disclosed privately to the Field Lead. Review this SWMS, the relevant JSA and SOP, the Field Plan and the site-specific ERP. Verify training currency — workers are not mobilised with expired mandatory training.	☐ Pre-field meeting ☐ SWMS / JSA / SOP reviewed ☐ ERP reviewed ☐ Training verified ☐ Medical disclosures
Vehicle failure, missing safety equipment or fatigue during travel	Complete the Pre-Travel Vehicle Safety Checklist — first aid kit, extinguisher, spare tyre, torch, water and PPE present; vehicle free from leaks, faults or damage; electrical issues visually inspected only and tagged out if unsafe. Complete the Journey Management Plan. Minimum 10-hour rest between shifts before driving; personal fatigue self-assessment before departure; rest breaks every two hours; carry water, snacks and electrolytes; second driver for long or remote trips where practicable. Zero blood alcohol concentration applies to all work driving.	☐ Vehicle checklist done ☐ JMP completed ☐ 10-hr rest confirmed ☐ Fatigue self-assessment
Travelling into fire, flood, storm, smoke or hazardous road conditions	Complete the Pre-Travel Environmental and Hazard Check using BOM weather warnings, Hazards Near Me, RFS fire danger ratings, Air Quality Index, lightning trackers, Live Traffic NSW and telecommunications coverage maps. Do not travel where there are emergency warning fire events, hazardous air quality, active storm warnings or flooded roads. Never drive through floodwater under any circumstance. If conditions change, stop, reassess and notify the Communication Officer.	☐ BOM / Hazards Near Me ☐ RFS rating checked ☐ AQI checked ☐ Live Traffic NSW ☐ Coverage checked
Hazards not identified, assessed or communicated before work commences	All team members participate in a pre-commencement Daily Toolbox Talk led on site by the Field Lead and documented on the EC WHS form — site-specific hazards identified; collaborative risk assessment using the EC risk matrix (rating one to six) with agreed controls and a revised residual rating; PPE and equipment readiness confirmed; ERP reviewed and Emergency Meeting Point identified; communication and check-in requirements confirmed; health or access needs disclosed privately; and worker sign-on confirming understanding and fitness for work. Hazards already in the EC Hazard Register are managed under the TARL. No worker commences without sign-on.	☐ Toolbox talk held ☐ Risk assessment rated ☐ Emergency Meeting Point ☐ All workers signed on
Loss of contact with the field team; delayed emergency response	Mandatory check-ins with the Communication Officer (0472 569 988) before departing base, on arrival at site or accommodation, before leaving site, and on return to base. Every check-in must be acknowledged. A missed or unacknowledged check-in triggers escalation through the Communication Officer, Project Lead or Project Manager, and the WHS Officer, and is grounds for activating the ERP. Carry redundant communications — mobile phone, UHF radio and In Reach or satellite communicator, with a PLB where remoteness warrants. Roles are assigned at the toolbox talk: Field Lead, Communication Officer and workers.	☐ Check-in schedule agreed ☐ Comms tested ☐ Roles assigned ☐ Escalation briefed
Site assessment, planning and competency		

What are the hazards & risks	What are the control measures	Select relevant controls (completed onsite by Field Lead)
Working near water bodies with slippery, unstable or eroded banks; unexpected deep water or drop-offs	Conduct a pre-site assessment identifying water depth and flow, bank stability, and access and egress points. Avoid steep, unstable or undercut banks. Establish safe work zones and exclusion areas. Minimum two-person team — no lone work near water.	☐ Site assessed ☐ Safe zones established ☐ Two-person team
Personnel entering water without capability; inadequate supervision or rescue readiness	Only competent and confident personnel are to work in or near water. At least one team member must remain on land at all times maintaining observation. Assign a responsible person for rescue readiness. Ensure at least one team member is trained in first aid and CPR. Ensure competent supervision at all times and provide training in water safety, hazard recognition and emergency response. Conduct pre-start briefings on site-specific risks.	☐ Roles assigned ☐ Competency confirmed ☐ Observer on land ☐ Supervision in place
High-risk zones — deep water, fast flow, submerged hazards; uncontrolled site access	Identify and isolate high-risk water areas. Use visual markers or barriers where required. Maintain safe setback distances from hazardous zones. Do not enter unknown or unassessed water areas.	☐ Hazards identified ☐ Areas isolated ☐ Setback maintained
Water entry preparation		
Carrying equipment while entering or exiting water; loss of balance	Maintain free movement and balance when entering water. Do not carry heavy or awkward loads into water — pass equipment to a person on the bank or stage it before entry.	☐ Load minimised ☐ Equipment staged
Hidden objects, debris and unstable substrate; strong currents or sudden drop-offs	Inspect the entry point before access. Test ground conditions using a pole or stick prior to entry. No diving under any circumstances. Controlled entry only, maintaining three points of stability. No entry above waist depth unless the risk is assessed and controlled. No work in fast-flowing water, flood conditions, poor visibility water, or unstable or unknown depth areas. Safe entry and exit points must be identified prior to commencing work and work must not proceed where safe egress cannot be maintained at all times.	☐ Entry point inspected ☐ Depth tested with pole ☐ No diving ☐ Below waist depth ☐ Egress maintained
Fieldwork in or near water		
Drowning or immersion; hypothermia or cold shock; slips, trips and loss of footing; isolation from rescue support	Implement the buddy system at all times — one person in water, one person observing from land. Maintain a safe working position and avoid fast-flowing or deep water. Pre-identify escape routes and safe exit points. Do not work in water where rescue is not immediately achievable. Carry spare dry clothing and monitor for cold shock and hypothermia — shivering, fatigue and confusion.	☐ Buddy system in place ☐ Escape routes identified ☐ Rescue achievable ☐ Dry clothing carried
Loss of communication between workers; delayed emergency response	Maintain continuous visual or verbal contact between team members. Use waterproof communication devices where required. Establish emergency signals and check-in intervals, and a communication check-in schedule with an emergency escalation path identifying who is called first. Immediate exit if communication is lost.	☐ Communication established ☐ Emergency signals agreed ☐ Escalation path set
Drowning due to lack of flotation; slips due to inappropriate footwear; equipment failure	Wear a Personal Flotation Device where working in water, or near deep or flowing water. Use appropriate footwear with grip. Inspect all equipment prior to use. Waders must not be relied upon as a flotation device and may increase drowning risk if filled with water — wear a belt at the waist and never enter fast-flowing or deep water in waders.	☐ PPE compliant ☐ PFD worn ☐ Equipment inspected ☐ Wader belt worn
Weather, hydrology and rescue readiness		

What are the hazards & risks	What are the control measures	Select relevant controls (completed onsite by Field Lead)
Rising water levels and flash flooding; increased flow rate; reduced visibility and footing	Check weather and upstream conditions prior to work. Continuously monitor water level and flow. Establish trigger points for evacuation based on rainfall and rising flow. Monitor tidal changes where applicable and consider upstream releases or dam discharge. Stop work during or after rainfall events that increase water risk.	☐ Conditions monitored ☐ Evacuation triggers set ☐ Upstream releases checked ☐ Tidal changes monitored
Delayed rescue response; inability to assist a person in water	Rescue must be undertaken using reach or throw methods where practicable — not by entering the water. Rescue equipment must be readily available, including a throw rope of at least 20 metres and a buoyancy aid. Personnel must not enter water to attempt a rescue unless trained and authorised. Rescue is to be performed from a safe position where possible. Assign responsibility for rescue equipment checks at the toolbox talk.	☐ Rescue equipment available ☐ Reach or throw only ☐ Equipment checks assigned

Stop-work triggers — stop work immediately, move to a safe location, notify the Field Lead and Principal Contractor, and do not recommence until the risk is controlled and communicated

Rising water levels or increasing flow rate	Fast-flowing, flood or unstable water conditions	Unknown or unsafe water depth	Slippery, unstable or eroded banks
Loss of visual or verbal contact between team members	Adverse weather, storms or poor visibility	Absence or failure of rescue equipment	Any situation where rescue cannot be immediately performed

Emergency response

Read with the site-specific Emergency Response Plan. The Field Lead is the Chief Warden. Any worker may activate the ERP.

1 · Activate & make safe	Stop work and ensure the area is safe for responders. Do not move an injured person unless there is immediate danger. For a person in the water: reach or throw — do not go . Use the throw rope or reaching aid from a stable position on the bank. Account for all personnel by headcount, exit all remaining workers from the water, isolate the hazard area where practicable, and notify the Field Lead or Site Supervisor. Manage the casualty for drowning, cold shock and hypothermia. Reassess conditions and controls before recommencing, and do not recommence until risks are adequately controlled and communicated. The Field Lead assesses the situation, initiates the response, directs evacuation to the Emergency Meeting Point, accounts for all personnel using the Daily Toolbox Talk sign-on sheet, and coordinates communication with the office.
2 · Call for help	Call 000 or 112, or activate the In Reach or PLB where there is no coverage. Provide GPS coordinates and the nearest cross roads, the nature of the emergency and safe access routes. Assign one person to guide responders in.
3 · First aid	A trained first aider assesses the casualty, but only where it is safe to do so. Control bleeding, immobilise suspected fractures and monitor breathing. If unconscious but breathing, place in the recovery position; if not breathing, commence CPR. Record all treatment on the First Aid Treatment Log.
4 · Post-incident	Report to the WHS Officer and complete an Incident Report Form within the required timeframe, submitted through the digital WHS platform. The WHS Officer updates the Incident Register and notifies the regulator of any notifiable incident. Attend debrief; review and update this SWMS and the ERP; restock emergency equipment used. Psychosocial support is provided where workers were exposed to distressing events.

Emergency services	000 or 112	State Emergency Service (SES)	13 25 00
EC office / Check-in Officer	0472 569 988	Managing Director / WHS Officer	Tony Webster · 0448 439 334
Poisons Information Hotline	13 11 26	Wildlife rescue	1300 094 737
Employee Assistance Program	1300 172 327 — free and confidential	Nearest hospital & muster point	Identified per site in the ERP; confirmed at the toolbox talk

Training & competency requirements

Required for this activity	Provide First Aid (HLTAID011) and CPR are mandatory for all personnel working in or near water, with Remote First Aid (HLTAID013) for remote sites. Training in water safety, hazard recognition and emergency response is provided and refreshed. Only personnel specifically trained and authorised in water rescue may enter water to perform a rescue.
Baseline — all field personnel	White Card (General Construction Induction); current driver's licence of appropriate class; CPR certification (annual renewal); Provide First Aid (HLTAID011), and Remote First Aid (HLTAID013) for remote or isolated work; General Fauna Handling Training.
Verification	All training must be current, recorded and verifiable prior to mobilisation. Records are maintained by the Administration Officer and retained for a minimum of five years, with expiry notifications issued in advance; workers are not mobilised with expired mandatory training. Competency is verified annually and observed on site by Principal or Senior Ecologists, Project Managers and the WHS Officer. Subcontractor training evidence is collected and retained for audit.

Daily SWMS acknowledgement & sign-on register

All personnel must read, understand and sign this SWMS before commencing work, confirming they are fit for duty, competent and able to perform assigned tasks safely. Completed with the Daily Toolbox Talk and submitted through the digital WHS platform.

#	Name	Role	Signature	Date
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				

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